

Meet Chris Ryan. A voice for Common Sense & Action in Squamish

I would like to introduce myself to the Squamish community: I am Chris Ryan. I first moved to the Sea to Sky Corridor in the summers of 1986, 1987, and 1988 to work and save money for college, where I studied marketing, retail management, and ski racing on the Sheridan College ski team. After college, I went straight into the real estate field for five years, with continued studies in property law, property appraisal, and mortgage financing.

I moved back full-time in 1993, and for the past 30 years, I have helped small businesses in the Sea to Sky Corridor achieve their goals through various advertising mediums like the *Whistler Question*, *Whistler This Week*, and Western phone directories. I also seasonally operated a property maintenance company for 20 years. My full history is available on LinkedIn.

I met my partner and her two boys 24 years ago, and we raised them in Pemberton. We moved to Squamish in 2018 and have lived in Garibaldi and downtown. I have had some work gaps over the past few years due to a bad car accident, and I am now working in the renewable energy solutions industry while landscaping one day a week in the summer. My passions lie within the water, the trees, the mountains, the environment, and cooking for my loved ones with vegetables from my community garden which we need more of.

Working Together for Our Community Goals

Now, let's talk about you, your town, and how your tax dollars are being used in our current environment. First of all, we need to address the elephant in the room: we cannot be fighting the provincial government's projects and expect them to fund our community projects. We need to work with and advocate to all levels of government to help achieve our community goals and needs.

Smart Parking Solutions for Loggers Lane

Parking for visitors, employees, and residential overflow is an ongoing problem in all neighbourhoods. Downtown, we can catch two apples with one hand by addressing parking and the expansion of the Feather Park bike lane, which currently leads into a gravel pit and goes nowhere. The solution: acquire the rail line on Loggers Lane from

the provincial government's BC Rail Corporation and the lessee, CN Rail, to continue the bike lane down to Hunter Place Road. This would allow us to create angled parking that is paid for by visitors but available to our residents and employees with a permit.

A Second Downtown Artery and Improved Infrastructure

A bigger need is a second arterial access route for downtown. The increase in condos and visitors is creating major congestion. One bad accident on Cleveland Avenue and traffic across the whole town grinds to a halt. It would cause a complete shutdown in and out of downtown. Bailey Street should be paved and opened to the business park for this purpose. At the same time, we should create paved parking for Bailey Street residents to replace the overflow parking area that remains a mud pit for most of the year. Parking is needed in all parts of our community as our housing becomes more expensive and several incomes are required to support a mortgage or rent.

Adopting the Whistler Housing Authority Model

On the topic of housing, we can adopt the successful model used by the Whistler Housing Authority for the past 30 years, which will help our seniors, locals, and employees stay in our community. This model uses covenants regarding room or suite rental rates and caps on real estate value increases. The model gives local residents opportunities to get into the housing market and allows seniors to downsize while staying in the community where their children and friends live, all while contributing to the tax base. We need to revisit the Cheema land proposal where this could be possible, incorporating high density, low sprawl family housing for our community. This will enable our town to grow beyond one- and two bedroom downtown condos. I will constantly and always advocate to the provincial and federal governments for affordable and senior housing. Currently, builders are required to include second-level office space in residential complexes. While most of these are sitting vacant, they could be put to a better use like affordable and senior housing.

Funding Infrastructure Through Practical Partnerships

Contrary to my beliefs as a renewable energy advocate, we need to work with the LNG company, which can help financially support various projects in our community. This includes Brennan Park, reopening the Bailey Street tennis courts, and building a

skate/bike/ball court in Garibaldi for youth activities. We also need to offset our carbon footprint with renewable energy on our municipal buildings, school buildings, and new constructions. The council complains a lot about LNG but does nothing themselves except switch to LED lights.

Connecting Our Regional Transit Network

For transit, we need to open the Darrell Bay bus route during the winter months perhaps running three times a day for the community, workers, and citizens so they can enjoy our parks without having to drive their cars and pay for parking at Darrell Bay. We also need to collaborate with our neighbouring towns to find a transit solution that connects all of the communities in the Sea to Sky Corridor.

Protecting Our Streetscapes and Tax Dollars

Streetscape infrastructure is being neglected downtown. There are two-foot weeds growing on our street curbs and sidewalks, bushes growing out of our storm sewer grates, and vegetation is only being managed one day a year at 4:00 a.m. right before the Loggers Sports Festival. As a landscaper, I know the power of a weed; they can pull up asphalt, split concrete curbs, and break sewer pipes. For a minor maintenance cost now, we will save the future tax base from the high costs of replacing our roads and streetscapes, all while beautifying the area for residents and visitors alike.

Addressing Traffic and Commercial Vehicle Costs

Our downtown roads are getting beaten up badly, leaving us with a massive tax bill. There are hundreds of overweight trucks transporting rolled metal and rebar cargo from the port through downtown. This cargo was originally intended to be put onto rail cars. Why isn't it? I was told the builders want their cargo faster in the city. At whose cost?

We also have a half-dozen food trucks downtown taking up to four parking stalls each while running dirty generators beside our sidewalks, businesses, and residents all day long. This is happening even though we have a new food truck court with electrical plug-ins at the corner of Main Street and Cleveland Avenue.

Accountability for Vacant Lots and Encampments

Builders need to supply sufficient parking instead of opting for cash-in-lieu, and they must maintain their vacant land. They could clean up their lots to create temporary parking solutions. Some are bad, but the worst lot is at the southwest corner of Loggers Lane and Vancouver Street, with an encampment consisting of trailers and tents. How is this allowed? Is the owner being fined? Adjacent to this on the waterway, there is a floating encampment of 20 derelict boats dumping raw sewage, fuel, and debris. Yet, we fight over the floatels at LNG.

Restoring Safety and Common Sense Downtown

Furthermore, the safe injection site needs to be removed from its location beside our public library, Montessori daycare, park, and local residents. We live in fear downtown. I alone have been attacked with a wooden spear, a pipe, needles, and rocks. It is not safe.

We need common sense on these issues in our community, and I will be the voice of common sense on council, operating with an open door and complete transparency. I will not be cluttering our streetscape with campaign signs, and I am accepting no political contributions.

I do need to apologize in advance as I will be absent from the debate on October 5th. Our son, Kirkland, and his fiancé, Katherine, are getting married out of province, and I need to visit my 93-years-young mother while I am close by.

A Voice of Common Sense for Squamish We need common sense for our community. I will be that voice.

Chris Ryan

Living, Working, and Playing in the Sea to Sky for 40 years

